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New York

President: Mr. Yang .....(Cameroon)

In the absence of the President, Mr. Da Cruz (Angola), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The meeting was called to order at 10 a.m.

Agenda item 66

Report of the Human Rights Council

Report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1)

The Acting President: An addendum to the annual report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53) is to be issued in due course to cover the fifty-seventh session of the Council, which concluded on 11 October. In connection with this item, I would like to recall that the General Assembly, at its 2nd plenary meeting, on 13 September, decided to consider agenda item 66 in plenary meeting and in the Third Committee, pursuant to resolution 65/281 of 17 June 2011.

It is my honour to welcome Ambassador Omar Zniber, President of the Human Rights Council. I would like to take this opportunity to commend his leadership in steering the work of the Council, especially during a challenging time that has been defined by an increasingly complex geopolitical context. It is a time when we are witnessing declining respect for human rights alongside rising discrimination and inequality; a time when civilians are being killed daily in conflicts around the world; a time when international law, including international human rights law, is being wielded as a weapon to gain political advantage rather than as a shield to protect those on the front lines of crises. Against that background, the Council's role in safeguarding and upholding the rights and dignity of all members of the human family is paramount. The presentation of its annual report today offers a key moment for reflecting on how we can further strengthen synergy between the Human Rights Council and the General Assembly.

Human rights are one of the three pillars of the United Nations. They are essential to our global mission to secure a just, safe and equitable world. With the adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) and its annexes, we reaffirmed our commitment to upholding human rights for everyone, everywhere. Today, respect

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for human rights is deteriorating globally, the result of several interlinked crises — those of climate change, displacement, famine, poverty and spiralling cycles of conflict. Nowhere is that more visible than in the Middle East, where the scale of destruction has led to intolerable suffering in Gaza, a mounting death toll in Lebanon and a renewed risk of conflagration throughout the region. Conflicts everywhere must end. They erode our humanity and dignity and undermine our aspirations for a better future.

Despite all those challenges, the Human Rights Council has continued to address a multitude of recurrent and emerging human rights issues while responding to urgent situations. We must always be guided by the noble principle enshrined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which is crystal clear in its statement that "All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights." We must recommit to upholding the Declaration's timeless principles, as we pledged to do last year in commemorating the seventy-fifth anniversary of its adoption by the General Assembly. Upholding human rights must remain our shared responsibility, guiding all our actions as we work to meet our commitments. On behalf of the President of General Assembly, H.E. Philémon Yang, I want to convey his full commitment to supporting those efforts.

In accordance with resolution 65/281, I now give the floor to the President of the Human Rights Council.

Mr. Zniber (Morocco): President, Human Rights Council: It is an honour to address the General Assembly today in my capacity as President of the Human Rights Council, and to present the annual report of that essential body (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). I would like to begin by congratulating the newly elected members of the Council.

The annual report and its addendum contain the resolutions, decisions and presidential statement adopted by the Council at its three regular sessions in 2024. During the reporting period, the Council adopted a total of 139 texts, addressing a wide range of thematic and country-specific human rights issues. Despite the general international atmosphere, as well as a lack of financial resources, the Council advanced its work of promoting and protecting human rights by facilitating dialogue and limiting the polarization that has threatened its ability to fulfil its important mandate and tasks.

It is also important to underline that the Council has worked, and is still working, on an almost permanent basis throughout the year, given the diversity and weight of the issues and matters it has to deal with, as well as the active involvement of its membership and all stakeholders. That has been demonstrated through the new thematics introduced this year and the adoption of new related texts. In my presidency, and in awareness of those challenges, I continued my predecessors' efforts to strengthen the Council's efficiency and effectiveness through various processes, especially those relating to the rationalization of initiatives, the Universal Periodic Review and the use of new technologies within the Council, matters closely linked to the work being done here in New York. Bearing in mind the future decisions that the General Assembly will have to make concerning the future of the Human Rights Council, the membership in Geneva has been ever more actively engaged in those processes, preparing in the best possible way to establish how the Council itself can express reflections and suggestions towards that goal.

This year the Human Rights Council once again further broadened the range of the human rights issues on its agenda. The issues included those regarding a culture of peace, discrimination against intersex persons, the protection of seafarers, the safety of the child, the elimination of domestic violence and the social integration of

persons released from prison. Those new thematic resolutions bring with them newly mandated activities such as reports, studies, workshops, panel discussions and intersessional meetings. The Council also continued its focus on technical assistance and capacity-building in many countries.

Throughout its three regular sessions this year, the Council also dealt with human rights issues linked to the current conflicts around the globe, especially those affecting civilian populations, creating harsh tensions at the international level and having negative consequences for respect for international humanitarian law. The Council has regularly pronounced on and drawn attention to the importance of protecting civilian populations and respecting international human rights obligations, whether in the Middle East, Europe or Africa, as well as on other situations with severe impacts on respect for human rights.

Some of the resolutions that the Human Rights Council adopted this year made recommendations to the General Assembly. They include resolution 55/20, on the situation of human rights in Myanmar, resolution 55/22, on the situation of human rights in the Syrian Arab Republic, and resolution 55/28, on the human rights situation in the occupied Palestinian territory, including East Jerusalem. Besides that, resolution 57/25 encouraged the General Assembly to proclaim a second International Decade for People of African Descent, while resolution 57/15 invited the Assembly to consider holding a high-level plenary meeting on the occasion of the twentieth anniversary of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples. Additionally, in April the Council adopted by consensus decision 55/116, by which it requested the Assembly to consider authorizing the Human Rights Council to continue its practice of using remote participation modalities for all of its future formal and informal meetings during its sessions, its organizational and intersessional meetings and the meetings of its subsidiary bodies and mechanisms, including the Working Group on the Universal Periodic Review, in accordance with the relevant resolutions of the Assembly and the Council.

The Universal Periodic Review continues to be one of our most results-oriented processes, creating a positive, constructive atmosphere within the Council. This year, the Council's annual panel discussion on technical cooperation and capacity-building put a particular focus on the implementation of Universal Periodic Review recommendations. During the discussion, States from every region called for prioritizing the funding for their implementation.

Interacting with special procedures remains one of the Council's essential activities, especially given the procedures' role in clarifying situations and answering important questions as requested by their mandates. That is why the norms and principles governing the mechanism must be preserved and respected, so that the Council can fulfil its duties in conformity with the decisions it takes on various issues, while also keeping in mind the diversity of the thematics and issues dealt with through the special procedures and the necessity for the Council to consider the outcomes in an acceptable and rationalized approach. It is in our best interests to cooperate with all the mandates established by the Council.

By its nature, the Council should be as inclusive as possible. In that regard, I want to strongly underline the important role being played by small island developing States and least developed countries in the Council's work and deliberations. We should not need to highlight the value added by the contributions of small island developing States and least developed countries on various agenda items, especially those related to their main concerns, which include development, climate change and surmounting vulnerabilities. This is why we must make every effort to put in place the logistics needed to facilitate such contributions to the Council's work. I would like to take this opportunity to commend the generosity of the donors who have

contributed to the voluntary trust fund for the participation of small island developing States and least developed countries in the Council's work.

The question of accessibility for persons with disabilities must also remain at the core of our efforts, with the aim of ensuring equal participation for all the Council's members and stakeholders. And I want to draw the Assembly's attention to the fundamental role played in the work of the Council by national human rights institutions and non-governmental organizations. They enrich our debates by bringing unique perspectives, along with detailed information based on their first-hand knowledge and proximity to the field, close to the populations the Council is mandated to serve.

(spoke in French)

In presenting today's report, I also want to take the liberty of highlighting the initiatives that the Moroccan presidency has encouraged during this year's work. In that respect, I have personally ensured that informal presidential discussions were held on subjects of great concern with regard to their specific impacts on people's enjoyment of human rights. That was the case in the discussions on the impact of climate change on food security and health security, as well as on the effects of artificial intelligence and the challenges it poses to the protection of human rights. The topics were addressed with substantial and meaningful contributions from international organizations, represented by their leadership, as well as from academics and experts, who provided insights that will soon enable the Council to take ownership of such issues, directly linked to guaranteeing human rights. The results, recommendations and summaries of the discussions have been compiled in documents shared with the presidency of the General Assembly, in New York, as well as with the co-facilitators responsible for preparing the Summit of the Future and the Global Digital Compact.

Incidentally, in that regard I believe that closer coordination between the Council and a number of agencies dealing with issues of concern to the Council can only be beneficial. The presidency has also made a point of including among its priorities the issue of gender equality, aware that it is also considered at the same level here in New York. In Geneva that resulted in the establishment of an advisory council to support the efforts of the presidency of the Human Rights Council. Its composition also reflects the importance of the entire Geneva ecosystem, which will contribute to enriching the debates and reflections that will take place.

Before concluding, I would like to emphasize, unsurprisingly, the extent to which the issue of financing the Human Rights Council and its activities has become a priority. The presidency is aware of that major challenge and has stepped up its efforts to streamline the Council's work and efficiency, doing everything possible to overcome the ever-increasing burden of the numerous mandates adopted by the Council and the requests associated with them.

(spoke in Arabic)

In closing, my presentation of the report of the Human Rights Council, I would be remiss if I did not express my deep gratitude to the High Commissioner for Human Rights and the staff of the Commission for the strong support that he has shown to the Council in allowing us to perform our mandated tasks aimed at improving the protection of human rights and fostering them all over the world. I would also like to commend the constructive cooperation and the spirit of fruitful understanding and dialogue that the Human Rights Council has enjoyed with the High Commission, in our common desire to serve the noble goals of this Organization, support multilateral diplomacy and achieve our shared goals of upholding and respecting internationally

recognized human rights, including civic, economic, cultural, political and social rights.

The Acting President: I would like to thank the President of the Human Rights Council for his report.

Mr. Pérez Ayestarán (Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela) (*spoke in Spanish*): The Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has the honour to be taking the floor on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defense of the Charter of the United Nations, whose Member States have noted the most recent report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1), which has just been presented pursuant to resolution 60/251 of the General Assembly.

Human rights are the broadest manifestation of the ideals that inspired the establishment of the United Nations, where multilateralism, mutual respect and dialogue are especially important in enabling us to make progress, particularly in the area of human rights. We would like to express our deep concern about the current catastrophic human rights situation of the Palestinian people, particularly in the Gaza Strip and regarding their human rights. The current situation is a genuine tragedy. It is a disgrace to the human rights system and that of the entire United Nations as a whole. We are seeing an occupying Power commit terrible atrocities against the life and dignity of a heroic people, while our international organizations appear powerless to halt the criminal actions of an occupying Power that is committing genocide and denying people the most basic human rights essential to life.

The Group of Friends attaches particular importance to the protection and promotion of all human rights, individual and collective, without distinction in level or category. We also consider that their promotion and protection are strengthened on a basis of dialogue and cooperation, in accordance with the principles of impartiality, objectivity, transparency, non-selectivity, non-politicization and non-confrontation, and also taking into account respect for the principles of sovereignty and non-interference in matters that are essentially within the domestic jurisdiction of any State, as set out in the Charter of the United Nations, and all of it within a framework of equality and mutual respect. In that regard, we expect the Human Rights Council, as an institutional force of the first order, to act effectively to bring the United Nations system closer to sustainable, advanced and balanced solutions. Those solutions should be in line with the context of today's world in addressing issues pertaining to human rights, always prioritizing dialogue and cooperation with States and ensuring that they are not weaponized by external actors seeking to advance dubious interests and agendas.

In that regard, we want to remind the Assembly that the Universal Periodic Review is the most appropriate and non-discriminatory mechanism for constructive discussions of human rights situations around the world. We also consider it vital that the Human Rights Council continually review and update its own mechanisms and working methods within the framework of the relevant provisions of its resolution 5/1, in order to preserve the ideals that inspired its creation and to avoid the practices that led to the failure of its predecessor.

We would like to take this opportunity to reiterate our categorical rejection of double standards in the arena of human rights, bearing in mind that such an approach is an obstacle to the establishment of a harmonious environment and progress in this area. We are also seriously concerned about the continued proliferation of mechanisms and procedures that claim to make so-called impartial assessments of the human rights situation in certain States and that in most cases lack not only the due consent and participation of the State in question but also base their reports on secondary, tertiary or other sources that can be partial or lack credibility. That

ultimately turns such documents into mere propaganda pamphlets, while enabling them to claim legitimacy simply because of the fact that they are issued by bodies of our Organization. In that context, we cannot overemphasize the importance of ensuring that the Organization, its name, and the spirit that should guide its efforts are not misused in order to advance aims contrary to the purposes and principles enshrined in its own founding Charter.

For its part, the Group of Friends reaffirms its condemnation of the sustained and increasing imposition of unilateral coercive measures aimed at advancing interventionist and destabilizing agendas, both political and economic, that have a massive impact on the ability of more than a third of humankind to fully enjoy their human rights. These are cruel, inhumane aggressions that not only violate all human rights — in particular the right to life, health, food and development — but also severely impact the policies, capacities and programmes of the Governments of more than 30 countries around the world, including with regard to their implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and their achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals. That is a reality that particularly affects people in vulnerable situations and that is contrary to our collective promise to leave no one and no country behind.

In that connection, we should emphasize that it is immoral and completely contradictory for some Governments to claim that they are champions and so-called guardians, defenders or promoters of human rights, when at the same time, through their deliberate and systematic policies, particularly the illegal application of unilateral coercive measures, they are committing mass violations and even crimes against humanity against the human rights of billions of people around the world on a daily basis. These things are quite simply unacceptable and incompatible with their claims.

The States members of the Group of Friends reiterate their belief that there can be no option other than that of dialogue, cooperation, engagement and national ownership in every process that is truly aimed at strengthening human rights, both at the national and international levels. We reaffirm our firm determination to continue working actively and constructively to improve the effectiveness and scope of the United Nations human rights system, including by strengthening the institutional capacity of the Human Rights Council. We also welcome the Council's recent adoption of its resolution 57/19, on the right to development, and we greatly value the Council's presentation to the General Assembly on the draft international convention on the right to development. We expect that pursuant to resolution 78/203, the process for its consideration, negotiation and subsequent adoption will begin in the next few months without further delay. After the almost 40 years that we have waited patiently to see this move forward, we hope that the entire membership of our Organization will join constructively in the upcoming discussions in order to see the convention adopted.

We want to conclude by affirming our determination and willingness to continue contributing to an approach that promotes multilateralism, and that is complemented and multiplied in a transparent way with other United Nations bodies. Only through measures that foster mutual and genuine trust, despite our possible differences, will we able to advance the promotion, protection and full guarantee of all human rights and a more just, democratic and inclusive international society, with full guarantees for the ideals that led to the establishment of the United Nations and that today all of our peoples are demanding as never before.

I would now like to add some brief comments in my national capacity. Over the past 10 years, the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has been subjected to a multifaceted aggression in the form of more than 947 unilateral coercive measures,

aimed ultimately at destroying the entire economic, social and political system that the Venezuelan people took the decision to build in their exercise of their right to sovereignty and free self-determination. It is an effort spearheaded by the Government of the United States, together with its satellite States, including in the European Union, to undermine not merely the capacity of the Venezuelan State and its institutions but our entire nation. The same countries that are daily violating the human rights of the Venezuelan people through their brutal application of a policy of maximum cruelty — and exploiting human rights, the Human Rights Council and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, including by creating mechanisms that are clearly political, biased and interventionist, even amid an apparently selective liquidity crisis — are not only trying to present themselves as so-called guardians of human rights before the entire world but even lecturing the rest of the world and our country about it. While not surprising, it is nonetheless a grotesque demonstration of their cynicism and double standards on this and many other issues.

In spite of those criminal actions, Venezuela remains committed to upholding its people's right to the full enjoyment of all their human rights. From this rostrum, we demand that the United Nations system, including the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, raise its voice, speak out against this issue and call for all of these unilateral coercive measures to be fully lifted everywhere. As has been widely reported on in many areas, they have had a negative impact on human rights, including those of more than 30 million Venezuelans.

In conclusion, I want to categorically reject the use of human rights as a political weapon. We also call on the responsible members of the Assembly to embrace the true spirit of human rights in the interests of the peoples whom we are called on to serve and to advance towards the full realization of one of the pillars that underpins our Organization.

Ms. Jóhannsdóttir (Iceland): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of Denmark, Finland, Norway, Sweden and my own country, Iceland, as a Nordic member-elect of the Human Rights Council for the 2025–2027 term. I thank the President of the Human Rights Council for his presentation of the report of the Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1), giving us an opportunity to discuss and reflect on its work.

The Nordic countries are firmly committed to promoting and protecting human rights of everyone, everywhere and at all times. As the Human Rights Council is the pre-eminent multilateral forum dedicated to the advancement of human rights, the Nordic countries attach great importance to its mandate. It will be crucial to make further improvements in synergies and the division of labour between the Human Rights Council and the Third Committee, while at the same time ensuring that the Council's mandate, independence and work are respected.

The Council is a vital platform for dialogue between States from all regions on the importance of advancing human rights and fundamental freedoms. That is why the Nordic countries emphasize the importance of engaging in the Council's work. Finland has served on the Council since early 2022, and Iceland was elected by the General Assembly in October to serve as a member of the Human Rights Council for the 2025–2027 term. During its term, Iceland will contribute actively to the Council's core mandate of advancing the promotion and protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms for all and of addressing human rights violations and abuses.

Unfortunately, we are witnessing a backlash against support for human rights and democratic norms worldwide. Human rights obligations are not respected, and we are seeing attempts to weaken established human rights norms. We are facing a

full-scale war in Europe, horrific conflicts with unacceptable civilian death tolls in the Middle East and other parts of the world, and autocratic tendencies rising once again. Against that backdrop, we stress that the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, drafted as a key instrument to prevent future horrors, is more relevant than ever. We must uphold the promise we made in adopting that Declaration. We must uphold the values of democracy, freedom and human rights, including freedom of expression and assembly. We must support a vibrant civic space and protect human rights defenders worldwide. Dialogue is key, even when we disagree, as its absence serves only to protect human rights violators. Our work in the Council can have a great impact for the benefit of people around the world, and that must be our goal — improving the lives of individuals on the ground. In that context, the Nordic countries stand firm in support of the vital work of the Office of the High Commissioner for the promotion and protection of human rights, including through ensuring adequate, predictable and sustainable financing.

As we reflect on the work of the Human Rights Council over the past year, we note that important resolutions have been adopted on dire human rights situations in the world, including in Russia, Afghanistan, Belarus, Iran, the Sudan and Ukraine in the context of Russia's war. The Nordic countries have engaged in the Council's discussions on the catastrophic humanitarian situation in Gaza. The Council has also adopted critical resolutions on the elimination of gender-based discrimination and violence (resolution 56/19). The Nordic countries will continue to engage in open and constructive dialogue with all the members of the Human Rights Council, recognizing that the Council draws strength from its diversity. We will stand up for those whose human rights are under threat or being violated and encourage all the States Members of the United Nations to fulfil their human rights obligations in order to progress towards our common goal of advancing the dignity and equality of all.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the representative of the European Union, in its capacity as observer.

Mr. Lambrinidis (European Union): I have the honour to speak on behalf of the European Union (EU) and its member States. The candidate countries North Macedonia, Montenegro, Albania, Ukraine and the Republic of Moldova, as well as Andorra, Monaco and San Marino, align themselves with this statement.

The European Union would like to thank Ambassador Omar Zniber for presenting the Human Rights Council's annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) to the General Assembly. We commend him for his commitment to steering the work of the Council at a time when serious human rights crises across the world continue to intensify, but also at a time when more people and more countries around the world are striving to assert greater and more hopeful ownership of all human rights for the benefit of everyone's humanity.

The Council has proved its relevance time and again since its establishment in 2006 by addressing urgent human rights situations around the world and tackling new and emerging challenges. The European Union has been a strong supporter of the Human Rights Council from day one and is determined to remain so. With its system of special procedures, investigative mechanisms and the Universal Periodic Review, the Council continues to contribute significantly to the promotion and protection of human rights worldwide. It has been another busy year in the Council, as the international community continues to grapple with new or expanding wars, conflicts, backsliding on democracy and increasing repression. Human rights violations are often among the root causes of conflicts. Together with growing poverty, food insecurity and the effects of climate change, such developments seriously challenge the realization of the Sustainable Development Goals and the attainment of human rights for all.

The European Union firmly believes in the founding principle of the United Nations that all human rights are equally important and mutually reinforcing, whether civil, political, economic, social or cultural. This year the EU welcomed the adoption of several thematic resolutions, including on the right to food (resolution 55/4) and adequate housing (resolution 55/11) and the right to safe drinking water and sanitation (resolution 57/13). We supported the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the right to a clean, healthy and sustainable environment (resolution 55/2) and were actively engaged in the cross-regional core group that successfully secured the consensus renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on human rights and climate change (resolution 57/31).

Together with the Group of Latin American and Caribbean States, we once again presented a draft resolution on the rights of the child (resolution 55/29), this time focusing on inclusive social protection. Furthermore, we led the work on the draft resolution on freedom of religion or belief (resolution 55/16) and supported resolution 56/7, on freedom of opinion and expression. Freedom of religion or belief cannot exist if freedom of expression is not respected. Both are necessary for an open and democratic society, as are media freedom and pluralism. We also supported the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the right to privacy (resolution 55/3), and we welcome the Council's focus on new and emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, and their effects on all human rights.

The European Union continued to actively promote gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls at every session of the Council and to support related resolutions, including two new initiatives calling on all States to take decisive and effective action to prevent and eliminate domestic violence in all its forms (resolution 57/18), and to seek to prevent and address technology-facilitated gender-based violence (resolution 56/19). Based on our long-standing commitments and priorities, we also supported resolution 55/12, on the absolute prohibition of torture and ill-treatment, as well as resolution 56/10, on the promotion and protection of human rights in the context of peaceful protests.

The European Union continues to protect and promote human rights both at home and abroad. We recognize that no country is perfect and that we all have work to do. For our part, we are open to dialogue and learning from others. The EU also cooperates fully with the United Nations human rights mechanisms. All 27 EU member States have issued a standing invitation to the United Nations special procedures, and we urge other States to do the same. Modern democracies should not be afraid of introspection but rather welcome scrutiny and strive for improvement. By the same token, the EU reiterates that the principles of sovereignty and non-interference in internal affairs do not free States from their obligations under international human rights law. Appeals to State sovereignty cannot be used to shield a country from scrutiny for its behaviour towards those within its own borders. The European Union is concerned about misuse of the sovereignty principle, as it erodes the entire multilateral system.

We welcome the work by the Human Rights Council to ensure the efficiency of its working methods, and we would like to remind everyone that it is up to the Council to decide on them. We would welcome enhanced coordination by the bureaus of the Council and the Third Committee to ensure synergies between the work of their two bodies. While we fully recognize that their workloads have grown, we believe that decisions on working methods should always be taken in an inclusive, consensual and carefully considered manner. This is not a matter of majority against minority. We have a joint responsibility to safeguard the system.

Over the past 12 months, the Council once again assumed its responsibility for responding to a number of situations where attention to human rights violations was

urgently needed. In a majority of the cases, resolutions were adopted by consensus. Among others, that was the case for the European Union-led resolutions on the human rights situation in Afghanistan (resolution 57/3), where the Taliban's gender-based discrimination may amount to gender persecution; in Myanmar (resolutions 55/20 and 56/1), where the military continues to commit the most atrocious crimes; and in the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (resolution 55/21). The draft resolutions on the human rights situation in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Central African Republic, Libya and Mali, presented by the African Group, as well as in Somalia, Sri Lanka and Colombia, were also adopted by consensus.

Twenty-six European Union member States, along with countries across the world, also supported the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur for the human rights situation in Russia, where the repression of civil society, human rights defenders, independent media and political opposition, as well as torture and ill-treatment in detention, have reached worrisome new levels since Russia began its unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression against Ukraine. We also supported the renewal of the mandate of the Commission of Inquiry on the human rights situation in Ukraine stemming from the Russian war of aggression (resolution 55/23), which recently reconfirmed its troubling finding of systematic and systemic torture of Ukrainian prisoners of war at the hands of Russia. The Council also addressed the grave human rights situation in Belarus, where there is complete impunity. The European Union also firmly supported the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Iran, as well as the Independent Fact-Finding Mission on the Islamic Republic of Iran, and called on Iran to facilitate the access of both to the country.

The European Union gave full support to the resolution renewing the Independent International Fact-Finding Mission for the Sudan, in order to investigate violations of human rights and international humanitarian law since the conflict's eruption in April 2023, thereby stressing the need for accountability for all crimes committed against civilians by those waging war in the Sudan. We also supported the extension of the mandates of the Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela and the Special Rapporteur on the Syrian Arab Republic and worked for the renewal of the mandates of the Special Rapporteurs on Burundi and Eritrea.

Just a few weeks ago, in his address to the Third Committee, Ambassador Volker Türk, the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, stated that "a closed, rigid, over-securitized approach does not make for safer societies or a safer world", that it "makes societies more likely to clash", and that instead "we must rebuild a world of openness, trust and respect". The European Union is concerned about the shrinking space for civil society, online and offline, all over the world. An independent and empowered civil society is an essential component of a healthy democratic system. To highlight the important role of civil society in international climate discussions, the EU initiated a joint statement, co-signed by 61 countries, with a special focus on the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change.

At the level of the United Nations, the European Union urges all States to respect and protect civil society and condemns any act or threat of reprisal against those who seek to cooperate with United Nations human rights mechanisms. The ability of individuals and groups to engage with the Council and its mechanisms without fear of reprisals is vital to the work of those mechanisms and the United Nations as a whole, and to our own daily efforts to promote peace, development and human rights for all.

Mr. Afoukou (Benin) (*spoke in French*): On behalf of the delegation of Benin, it is an honour for me to take the floor in this debate to share with you some specific comments on the work of the Human Rights Council in the period under review and beyond.

First, I would like to express to all members of the United Nations the appreciation of my country and its leaders for the renewed trust so excellently shown to us on 9 October 2024 in the broad support for our re-election to the Human Rights Council for the 2025–2027 term. We also would like to warmly congratulate the other elected and re-elected members of the Council. We want to assure our fellow members of our firm determination to work closely with them, as well as with other Member States and relevant stakeholders, to advance the cause of human rights in a world that is more perilous than ever.

Secondly, with regard to the agenda item under consideration, Benin takes note of the annual report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) and thanks the President of the Council, Ambassador Omar Zniber, for presenting the report to the General Assembly in accordance with resolution 60/251. The report bears witness to the broad scope of work undertaken by the Council in the period under review, which addressed many human rights issues, investigating violations of human rights around the world, despite the increasingly difficult circumstances in which the Council is forced to carry out its mandate. In that context, I would like to reiterate that Benin attaches particular importance to the Human Rights Council and is proud to be a member of this leading multilateral forum dedicated to human rights, participating actively and constructively in the Council's work since joining it in 2022.In addition to its participation in all Council sessions, Benin was a member of the core group on the draft resolution on the death penalty, adopted in October 2023 (resolution 54/35). In addition, together with Belgium, Benin co-authored an initiative aimed at establishing vocational and technical education and training as an integral part of the right to education (resolution 53/7). Benin also co-sponsored resolution 49/7, on cultural rights and the protection of cultural heritage, adopted in March 2022.

Thirdly, Benin would like to emphasize that human rights are essential to the maintenance of peace, security and stability in the world and to our ability to achieve sustainable development. They therefore represent the base of the triangle that reinforces the other two fundamental pillars of our shared Organization — peace and development. The work of the Human Rights Council, even though it is conducted in Geneva, should therefore nevertheless also be a focus of our attention at the General Assembly in New York. We believe there should be better synergy between the two world capitals of multilateralism in order to ensure the necessary coherence of the work being done on human rights within the entire United Nations system. Benin reiterates its belief in the importance of an interactive dialogue between the Third Committee, which is responsible for social, cultural and humanitarian issues, and the Human Rights Council. Without prejudice to their respective functions, it is crucial that both these bodies continue to strengthen the coordination between the New York and Geneva Headquarters, particularly by continuing regular and constructive dialogue and engaging in close cooperation.

Lastly, I would like to stress the crucial importance of the special trust fund established in 2012 through Council resolution 19/26 for technical assistance to support the ability of least developed countries and small island developing States to participate in the Council's work. The fund is now an essential tool for universal participation in the work of the Human Rights Council. In particular, it ensures that least developed countries and small island developing States, particularly those that do not have a permanent mission in Geneva, can take part in and contribute to the work of the Council. Benin would like to warmly thank all the contributing countries.

We hope to see the number of contributors to the fund and the amounts they contribute increase further at the event to be organized on 15 November for that purpose by the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights in Geneva. In order for the fund to be more effective, the delegation of Benin emphasizes the importance of ensuring that in future we systematically maintain the least developed countries and small island developing States on the Council as the primary beneficiaries of the fund.

Ms. Chan Valverde (Costa Rica) (*spoke in Spanish*): Costa Rica thanks the President of the Human Rights Council for presenting its annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) to the General Assembly.

My country once again reiterates its firm support for the work of this important body, as we have done since we promoted its establishment in 2006, as well as for the work of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, the special procedures and the Universal Periodic Review mechanism. At the time, we advocated for a body that would be more effective and less politicized than its predecessor, and we stressed the importance of ensuring that its members maintained a genuine commitment to the promotion and protection of human rights, which is a permanent task and a tireless struggle. We cannot stop until we have achieved full respect for the dignity of all, regardless of their condition. We must move forward with determination, because only in constant progress can we find true justice for all. That is why we must work harder than ever to continue to guarantee the commitment of Member States to the Council, especially with regard to its efficiency and effectiveness in responding to the challenges facing society in 2024 and to those that future generations will face as well.

As the report points out, the evolution of our challenges demands a renewed commitment and the ability to adapt to ensure that human rights remain at the centre of our actions and policies. Costa Rica trusts that the special procedures, the treaty body committees and the Universal Periodic Review will strengthen the capacity of the international community to respond to those challenges and to human rights violations, and to promote greater responsibility. Since 2023, Costa Rica has held several interactive dialogues on the country reports it has submitted to the treaty body committees, thereby reaffirming its commitment to reporting and submitting to supervision on its implementation of human rights conventions, including the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, the Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment, the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance. We have also attended to multiple special procedures, among which the visits of Special Rapporteurs to Costa Rica stand out. Our door has always been open to their visits and to their conduct of the corresponding oversight when they deem it appropriate. On 3 September Costa Rica also reaffirmed its commitment to respect for human rights through its presentation of our fourth national report for the Universal Periodic Review, before which our country remains pending the recommendations and directions of work that may arise from the new cycle of the Universal Periodic Review.

The challenges mentioned in the report affect thousands of people’s enjoyment of human rights and cannot be effectively addressed until States assume greater responsibility for their international human rights obligations. Human rights deserve the same treatment as the other pillars of this organization because they are interdependent and mutually reinforcing. Costa Rica reiterates its firm position that the three pillars of the United Nations — peace and security, sustainable development and human rights — must receive equal priority and adequate funding. It is crucial

that the mandated bodies of our Organization have the necessary resources to fulfil their mission.

According to the latest report from the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, as of 1 June 2024, 346 reports from States parties were pending review, and 1,899 individual communications were being investigated. As at 18 June 2024, the Committee on Enforced Disappearances had 755 open cases covering a total of 1,086 individual cases treated separately or in groups. Costa Rica is concerned about the effect that the United Nations liquidity crisis is having on the work, efficiency and results of the human rights treaty bodies, the special procedures and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. We urge Member States to pay their contributions in full and on time.

In action 46 of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), Member States requested that the Secretary-General assess the need for adequate, predictable and sustainable funding of the United Nations human rights mechanisms, including the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, to enable the efficient and effective fulfilment of its mandate. Costa Rica echoes that request and calls for a comprehensive, thorough and lasting review of the functioning not merely of the human rights treaty body system but the entire human rights system generally. We also call for strengthening synergies between the General Assembly, the Human Rights Council and other bodies, both at the substantive level and in terms of efficiency and complementarities, so that national capacities, early warnings and other tools for compliance, monitoring and follow-up of human rights obligations can be improved and their effectiveness strengthened for the benefit of all people.

Ms. Al-Thani (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): We thank the President of the Human Rights Council for being here today and for presenting the Council's annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) and his comprehensive briefing.

A few weeks ago, Qatar was honoured to be elected to the Human Rights Council for the 2025–2027 term. We are proud of that achievement, which is a sign of the international community's trust and respect for Qatar and for the position that it has established over the years as an active and credible partner at the international level. We would like to take this opportunity to reiterate that Qatar will spare no effort in continuing the active and positive role that characterized its previous stint as a member of the Council and in collaborating constructively with Member States to enable the Council to achieve its noble goals.

Respect for human rights is a main pillar of Qatar's policies, and human development and the protection and promotion of human rights are among our top priorities. That is reflected in a constitutional and legislative framework that consolidates the principles of human rights and fundamental freedoms and ensures their respect and protection for all. We also view the Universal Periodic Review as an important opportunity to assess and identify challenges and best practices with the aim of making further progress in promoting and protecting human rights. We will submit our fourth national report to the Universal Periodic Review during the forty-seventh session of the Working Group on the Universal Periodic Review, to be convened in Geneva this month.

Qatar has maintained its support to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights and looks forward to continuing those efforts in future. We are also pleased to have hosted the United Nations Human Rights Training and Documentation Centre for South-West Asia and the Arab Region since 2009. The Centre's work is very relevant to the needs of the region and has contributed to the significant progress that has been made in strengthening human rights.

Our brother people of Palestine have been living with desperately harsh conditions and flagrant violations of their human rights since the start of the ongoing Israeli aggression on Gaza. The report of the Human Rights Council lists the decisions and resolutions, including those related to the situation of human rights in the occupied Palestinian territory, expressing alarm regarding the catastrophic humanitarian, social and economic conditions in the Gaza Strip that have resulted from Israel's repeated military operations against it. We condemn those grave violations and breaches of international humanitarian law and the international human rights law in the strongest possible terms, as well as all methods targeting civilians and attempts to forcibly displace the Palestinian people from the Gaza Strip.

Finally, we reaffirm our commitment to continuing our work in support of international efforts to consolidate the principles of human rights, respect and protect them for all, continue collaboration and multilateral action and engage actively with all partners to accelerate the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

Ms. Almulla (Kuwait) (*spoke in Arabic*)*:* At the outset, the State of Kuwait would like to thank the Human Rights Council for its efforts in preparing its report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). We are particularly interested in the General Assembly's consideration of its agenda item 66, which we view as a priority, especially considering that we are currently seeing flagrant human rights violations resulting from bloody conflicts and wars in every corner of the world. That is despite the fact that we have just commemorated the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

Kuwait is committed to its international human rights obligations. We are a party to seven of the nine core conventions in the area. We have also submitted our sixth periodic review under the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, and our report regarding progress on the implementation of the Beijing+30 programme of action, as well as our fourth periodic review of the Convention against Torture. We will present our fourth report to the Universal Periodic Review next year.

The continued flagrant violations of human rights around the world demand that some parties revisit their values, and the international community must uphold its responsibility to fight these crimes without hesitation. Unfortunately, we continue to see such acts of bloodshed and devastation occurring in our part of the world. Wars continue to claim innocent victims, and these tragedies are a flagrant violation of international law and a crime against humanity. From this rostrum, my delegation condemns Israel's brutal aggression against our brother Palestinian and Lebanese peoples in the strongest terms. It is a systematic policy of repression, killing and destruction, a full-fledged war crime targeting innocent civilians and internally displaced persons. Depriving them of their most basic human rights is a stain on humankind, and we call for an immediate ceasefire and for the lifting of the siege on the Gaza Strip, allowing humanitarian access and holding perpetrators accountable for their actions. We also welcome the Human Rights Council's decision to open an independent international investigation into Israeli crimes against the Palestinian people. We call on the international community to shoulder its responsibility for protecting the Palestinian people and to bring an end to the Israeli occupation. What is happening in Palestine is a massacre in every sense of the word. It cannot be ignored. The international community must act urgently to put an end to these crimes and hold the perpetrators accountable. The double standards and international silence regarding these crimes committed by the occupation represent complicity in the crime.

We call on all States to take urgent action to end the aggression and ensure that the Israeli occupation forces respect international law and protect the Palestinian people. We also call for an immediate cessation of the Israeli aggression against Lebanon. We strongly condemn the repeated acts of aggression against the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon, which are also a flagrant violation of international humanitarian law and demand immediate accountability.

In that context, my country reaffirms the importance of respecting the rule of law and applying international law without selectivity or discrimination. We condemn any deliberate attacks on the reputation of the Secretary-General in the strongest terms and oppose any attempt to undermine the role of the United Nations and its bodies. We emphasize that the systematic attacks on the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) are a flagrant violation of the immunity of United Nations institutions and of the Charter of the United Nations and the relevant United Nations resolutions. They are exposing Palestinian refugees to great risks. We firmly condemn the Israeli law classifying UNRWA as a terrorist organization. It is a desperate attempt to undermine UNRWA's work and deprive Palestinian refugees of their fundamental rights.

In conclusion, my country reaffirms its unwavering commitment to protecting human rights. We call for strengthening international cooperation with a view to achieving a world where everyone enjoys dignity and justice. We firmly believe that respect for human rights is the foundation of peace, security and stability. Ignoring human rights violations threatens the very future of humankind. We must work together to bring about a world where freedom, justice and equality are the norm and where human dignity is respected.

Mr. Prabowo (Indonesia): We would like to express our appreciation to Ambassador Omar Zniber of the Kingdom of Morocco for his outstanding leadership as President of the Human Rights Council and for the comprehensive report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) he presented today. As a current Vice-President of the Council, Indonesia remains committed to actively contributing to enhancing the Council's effectiveness. With a view to further optimizing the Council's mandate, I want to highlight three critical priorities.

First, the Council must adhere firmly to its core mandate to treat all human rights with fairness, equality and full recognition of their importance. In this era marked by intense geopolitical strife and widespread conflicts, the need for a principled and impartial Council has never been greater. It is unacceptable that on issues where unity is essential, the Council continues to face division. That fragmentation is most evident when it comes to addressing the dire human rights situation in Palestine and particularly the ongoing genocide in Gaza. Indonesia reiterates its steadfast support for the rights of the Palestinian people, and we urge the Council to adopt a more robust and united approach. We are also concerned about the fact that fragmentation is also evident in other issues of particular importance to developing countries, including the right to development, the elimination of unilateral coercive measures and actions against racism outlined in the New Urban Agenda (resolution 71/256, annex). Moreover, the Council must confront the alarming threats of intolerance and Islamophobia that we are seeing worldwide and ensure a consistent and decisive response.

Secondly, the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) is a pivotal document driving our collective commitment to advancing human rights. It stands as a powerful testament to our achievements and the critical work that lies ahead. The right to development, which this document enshrines as a fundamental human right, should not be a matter of division or repeated votes within the Council. We commend the intergovernmental working group in Geneva for its diligent work on a draft

international covenant on the right to development and call on all States to support the ongoing discussions in New York and expedite the adoption of that vital document.

Thirdly, enhanced coordination and synergy between New York and Geneva are essential to an effective United Nations human rights system. With an ever-growing number of resolutions in the Council, we must prioritize their impacts and guard against the politicization of human rights. While we acknowledge the Council's responsiveness to emerging issues, we caution against overstepping into the mandates of other organizations. Coordination is not just desirable, it is crucial. We must tailor our human rights approaches to uphold the rule of law and strengthen their implementation, including in support of countries' capacity to implement and foster cooperation. The global community cannot afford half measures in protecting human dignity. Let us, as Member States, work alongside all the relevant stakeholders with urgency, unity and genuine dialogue to address the pressing human rights challenges of our time.

Ms. Oehri (Liechtenstein): We thank the President of the Human Rights Council for presenting a comprehensive and informative account of the Council's work (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). The Council is the central United Nations human rights body, and as such it plays a crucial role in ensuring that States respect their obligations under international human rights law and in preventing and responding to violations of it. We would like to take this opportunity to flag some of the key aspects of the work of the Council during both the reporting period and its most recent session.

We welcomed the Council's unanimous adoption of resolution 55/20, on the situation of human rights in Myanmar, condemning in the strongest terms both the military coup and the country's continued extension of a state of emergency. As the current political developments in Myanmar point to the likelihood of protracted authoritarianism, with severe consequences for the life and livelihoods of the civilian population, it will be important for the international community to remain seized of the matter. In that regard, we echo the call of the Human Rights Council asking the Security Council to continue focusing on the situation with a view to resolving the humanitarian crisis. We also strongly support the call to Member States to cease participating in the illicit transfer and diversion of arms, munitions and other military equipment, including jet fuel. And we urge the Third Committee to adopt a resolution on the situation of Myanmar that is in line with that of the Human Rights Council, including in the area of accountability. The international community must work together to avoid further civilian casualties and ensure accountability for mass atrocities and human rights violations.

The human rights situation in Afghanistan remains an issue of grave concern, especially for women and girls suffering from the draconian curtailment of their most basic human rights and fundamental freedoms. While we welcomed the Council's unanimous adoption in early October of resolution 57/3, we would have preferred even stronger measures in response to the worsening crisis in the areas of human rights and gender persecution. Building on the stocktaking of accountability options decided last year, we would have especially welcomed the creation of an international mechanism mandated to investigate human rights violations as well as to collect, preserve and analyse evidence in order to address the pervasive impunity across the country. The persecution of women and girls in Afghanistan likely constitutes a crime against humanity. We would therefore like to remind everyone of the International Criminal Court's jurisdiction and its role in advancing accountability for that crime, among the many others committed in Afghanistan.

To ensure adequate reporting on the human rights situation, it is vitally important that the Special Rapporteur be able to enter Afghanistan and collect

information on the ground. In that regard, we echo the Council's condemnation of the recent decision of the Taliban to no longer grant access to the Special Rapporteur and call on it to reverse the decision and cooperate with United Nations human rights mechanisms. As long as they continue to disregard the most basic norms of human rights, we cannot see eye to eye with the Taliban.

In addition to the highest number of armed conflicts since the establishment of the United Nations, we are also facing an unprecedented human rights crisis. Serious violations of international human rights and humanitarian law are common in many armed conflicts. The conflicts are especially affecting civilians, and vulnerable individuals such as children in particular. In 2023 we saw a serious increase in grave violations against children in conflict situations, many of which are on the agenda of the Human Rights Council, ranging from the Sudan to Ukraine to Gaza. With the Assembly's renewal of the United Nations mandate on children and armed conflict coming up next year, we need to ensure that the relevant United Nations bodies work together closely in our common effort to protect children and ensure that their human rights are being respected at all times.

Close coordination between the Human Rights Council and other relevant United Nations bodies, as well as the creation of synergies, also remains relevant with regard to new and emerging human rights issues where the Council has demonstrated readiness and capability. We welcomed last year's timely adoption of resolution 53/29, on new and emerging technologies and human rights, highlighting the need for human rights safeguards to limit potential harm resulting from the fast-paced development of artificial intelligence. The resolution preceded and informed two General Assembly resolutions on artificial intelligence (resolutions 78/265 and 78/311), as well as the recent adoption of the more comprehensive Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I). With the immense potential of new technologies and artificial intelligence tools and their increased use around the world, it remains critical that we ensure an inclusive, open, safe and secure digital space that respects, protects and promotes human rights. Reducing the gender digital divide and countering the harmful gender bias that is mirrored in artificial intelligence is of particular importance. The risk that artificial intelligence poses to the right of privacy needs to be addressed in a holistic manner by all relevant stakeholders. In that regard, we welcomed the renewal in March of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the right to privacy in the digital age.

In the light of the ongoing discussions on improving the working methods of the Third Committee, we reaffirm our belief that close cooperation and coordination between New York and Geneva is essential to the successful advancement of the promotion and protection of human rights. We also appreciate the key contribution of civil society organizations to the work of the United Nations, including that of the Human Rights Council and the Third Committee, and welcome their active involvement. In that regard, we regret the trend of taking measures to restrict access to the United Nations in Geneva for civil society organizations, even those accredited at the United Nations, and ask that this trend be reversed.

The founding resolution of the Human Rights Council, resolution 60/251, provides that its members shall uphold the highest standards in the promotion and protection of human rights. The members of the Council, whether newly elected or incumbent, should be faithful to that mandate, as it is a prerequisite for the Council's effectiveness. We also call on Council members to cooperate fully with all entities, mechanisms and mandate holders of the United Nations human rights system, including standing invitations extended to special procedures and the High Commissioner.

Ms. Amorim Cardoso (Brazil): Brazil is currently serving its sixth fixed term on the Human Rights Council for 2024 to 2026. We are committed to exercising our vote and voice within the Council to ensure that it contributes effectively to sustainable and legitimate multilateral solutions.

The key priorities for Brazil include combating hate speech, disinformation, racism and all forms of discrimination and violence, as well as promoting gender equality, increasing the participation of indigenous peoples and enhancing corporate responsibility. The inadequacy of the financial resources for the United Nations human rights pillar and the technical capacities of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights is also of great concern to us.

Brazil believes that the work of the Council demands the active engagement and support of the international community. That is especially necessary in the light of various current challenges, such as the record number of ongoing armed conflicts, as well as significant setbacks to the rights of women and girls and in the areas of gender and diversity of sexual orientation. We must ensure that the framework of acquired rights is not rolled back, particularly considering that such individuals and groups suffer disproportionately from violations and abuses of human rights. We also stress the importance of strengthening the Universal Periodic Review and fostering cooperation and constructive dialogue within the Human Rights Council. Brazil takes pride in its commitment to promoting plurality, diversity, dialogue and the peaceful settlement of conflicts. The protection and promotion of human rights is therefore a natural and necessary priority. We once again reaffirm our commitment, nationally and internationally, to the full enjoyment of all human rights by all.

Brazil also believes in the importance of promoting the shared perspectives of the global South on human rights. Advancing human rights requires addressing economic and social inequalities on a global scale. Disparities in income distribution seriously limit access to essential services such as healthcare, education, food and sanitation. Brazil is dedicated to combating hunger and poverty and urges the international community to implement public policies that foster social justice and equitable income distribution.

Over the past few days, during the interactive dialogues held in the Third Committee, we had the opportunity to exchange views with special rapporteurs, independent experts and other mandate holders on the promotion and protection of human rights. We underline the importance of ensuring equitable geographic and gender representation in the selection of candidates for special procedures, particularly from developing countries.

Mr. Marschik (Austria), Vice-President, took the Chair.

Brazil reiterates that all human rights are universal, indivisible, interrelated, interdependent and mutually reinforcing, and that the same rights that apply offline must also be upheld online. Guided by that basic but crucial tenet, we will continue to call for and support all necessary steps towards the promotion and protection of human rights, in favour of a more equitable world for all, in line with the Sustainable Development Goals.

Mr. Ferreira Silva Aranda (Portugal): Portugal aligns itself with the statement made earlier on behalf of the European Union. I would like to start by thanking Ambassador Omar Zniber for presenting the report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) to the General Assembly, and for his tireless work and dedication as President of the Council. Portugal is very grateful for the way he has been carrying out his mandate.

As we confront pressing issues such as discrimination, rising inequalities and the impact of climate change on human rights, Portugal emphasizes the need for a rights-based approach to sustainable development. We believe that sustainable solutions must incorporate the voices of people in vulnerable situations, ensuring that their rights are upheld in every policy and initiative. Portugal also recognizes the vital role of civil society in advancing human rights. We advocate for an open space where human rights defenders and organizations can operate freely and safely. The voices of those who champion human rights must be heard, and their contributions must be integrated into our collective efforts. We are deeply concerned about the rise of authoritarianism and the erosion of democratic values in various regions. Portugal calls on all Member States to reaffirm their commitment to the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and to ensure that those rights are not merely theoretical but actively protected and promoted.

Portugal reiterates its unwavering support for the treaty bodies, the system of special procedures and the Universal Periodic Review mechanism. Portugal will be under review at that mechanism a week from now. At that unique mechanism of the Human Rights Council, we look forward to presenting concrete actions we have undertaken to improve the human rights situation in Portugal and to overcome challenges to people's enjoyment of human rights. Most importantly, we look forward to receiving its recommendations, which will also benefit from input from civil society in the service of our continuing improvement.

We are of the view that the Human Rights Council is the institutional crown jewel of our multilateral human rights system. Since 2006, Portugal has been an active player and a strong supporter of the Human Rights Council. In Geneva, we have led resolutions on the realization of economic, social and cultural rights; the right to education; mental health and human rights; and human rights in the context of HIV/AIDS. We are also a member of the core group on resolutions on youth and human rights; human rights and the 2030 Agenda; the elimination of discrimination against people affected by leprosy; and education as a tool for fighting racism.

The Assembly's adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), one of the greatest achievements of multilateralism in recent years, made it clear that even in times of polarization and multiple crises we can find spaces for consensus, for agreement and for transformative action. The Pact reaffirms that all three pillars of the United Nations are equally important, interlinked and mutually reinforcing. Portugal defends the principle of parity between all three of the United Nations pillars in both institutional and financial terms, and financially, we believe that allocating around 7 per cent of the overall budget to the human rights pillar is not adequate. However, we are not just advocating for parity. Mainstreaming human rights in all the United Nations pillars, strengthening the synergies between the Human Rights Council and the Security Council and including a human rights perspective in every single peace and security process demand further efforts.

In conclusion, our priorities are clear. Portugal will be there, whether we are talking about the universal abolition of the death penalty, the promotion of gender equality, the protection of the rights of persons in situations of vulnerability — including children, migrants and the elderly — the fight against racism, the efforts to combat all forms of discrimination, the realization of the right to education or health or the recognition of the human right to a clean, healthy and sustainable environment. We can always be counted on to stand up for human rights.

Ms. Saleem (Pakistan): Pakistan welcomes this opportunity to engage in a constructive discussion on the Human Rights Council's annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). We commend the President of the Human Rights Council for presenting a comprehensive account of the Council's work, which reflects its role in

addressing diverse and evolving human rights issues globally. The Council continues to serve as a critical forum for dialogue, cooperation and accountability. We reaffirm our commitment to its mandate to promote and protect human rights across the globe.

Established as a subsidiary body of the General Assembly, the Human Rights Council was envisioned as embodying transparency, impartiality and non-politicization, providing a just framework for addressing human rights issues worldwide. It is therefore troubling to see those foundational principles compromised by political biases, entrenched polarization and selective interests. As a member of the Human Rights Council, Pakistan believes that an inclusive and balanced approach that recognizes the diversity of human rights concerns across regions is essential to lasting progress. Pakistan is committed to upholding that principle by fostering constructive dialogue and avoiding politicization of the Council's work.

Today's global landscape is facing a spectrum of crises, from climate change to food, fuel and financial crises, amplifying inequalities, poverty and social injustice. Those challenges place substantial burdens on future generations. It is imperative that the Human Rights Council allocate its resources equitably across the spectrum of rights, balancing civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights, including the right to development. Upholding all human rights without a hierarchy will advance a balanced and comprehensive approach to dignity and equality worldwide. A more robust framework for addressing economic, social and cultural rights, including the right to development, will support our efforts to realize the Sustainable Development Goals. Owing to the broad range of crises confronting us, many countries face constraints on resources that impede their ability to fulfil their human rights obligations. We urge Member States and donor institutions to enhance their funding and technical support for capacity-building programmes. That assistance should be demand-driven, culturally sensitive and aligned with each country's unique socioeconomic context if it is to have a lasting impact.

We also remain concerned about the fact that the rise in racial hatred, religious extremism and violent nationalism has become more prominent, often spilling over into mainstream political discourse. In many regions, Islamophobia has been normalized, manifested through calls for expulsion, restrictions on religious expression, burnings of the Holy Qur'an and the defamation of Islamic symbols and sacred places. Such actions, often carried out in the guise of free speech, serve only to inflame division and violence. The Human Rights Council has a crucial role in addressing Islamophobia under its agenda item 9 and its prevention mandate. We urge the special procedures to investigate and present actionable recommendations to counter that rising threat, ensuring that human dignity is respected and that no community faces vilification and exclusion.

We believe that the Human Rights Council's prevention mandate should apply universally, particularly in cases of foreign occupation and alien domination that result in systematic rights abuses. We call on all Member States, especially those advocating for the Council's prevention agenda, to demonstrate true impartiality by addressing the situations of foreign occupation with decisiveness. The credibility of the Human Rights Council depends on its ability to approach country-specific situations under agenda item 4 without selectivity. No State, regardless of its power or influence, should be permitted to disregard fundamental human rights with impunity.

The Council must increase its focus on human rights violations in United Nations-recognized disputed territories, especially those under prolonged foreign occupation. Such situations often lead to draconian legislation by the occupying Powers, which exploit their control in order to evade accountability, restrict freedoms and suppress movements for self-determination. As a matter of international law and

morality, the right to self-determination remains fundamental. We call on the Council to give greater attention to the plight of populations living under foreign occupation as they face violations of fundamental rights, including denials of the right to self-determination, dignity and fundamental freedoms. The Human Rights Council should enhance the efforts to advocate for and support such populations through independent investigation and regular reporting.

The Council currently has around 90 special procedure mandates, both thematic and country-specific. That proliferation risks depleting resources and duplicating mandates, which undermines the effectiveness of the Council's work. We advocate for a streamlined, efficient system that focuses on quality over quantity, ensuring that mandates complement each other and prioritize the most pressing issues.

As a member of the Human Rights Council, Pakistan remains steadfast in its commitment to promoting and protecting human rights, nationally and internationally. We continue to advocate for constructive dialogue, engagement and consensus building within the Council and the Third Committee. We are hopeful that the Human Rights Council will rise to its mandate, championing the cause of human rights for all people in all regions without discrimination or prejudice. As we move forward, Pakistan remains resolute in its commitment to fostering a multilateral approach to human rights that transcends divisive politics and respects diverse cultural, religious and social contexts. The Human Rights Council, as the principal forum for human rights, must uphold those principles if it is to effectively serve the international community and address the challenges that the world is facing today.

Ms. Chanda (Switzerland) (*spoke in French*): Switzerland thanks the President of the Human Rights Council for his report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). We welcome today's exchange of views, because the kind of dialogue that strengthens the link between Geneva and New York is also important for Switzerland, as the host country of the Human Rights Council.

Switzerland welcomed the work of the Human Rights Council over the past year and is glad to have contributed to it. Working with other States, for instance, we introduced and ensured the adoption of resolution 56/10, on the promotion and protection of human rights in the context of peaceful protests. We also secured the adoption of a decision on remote participation for hybrid meetings of the Human Rights Council (decision 55/116). We encourage the General Assembly to adopt a mandate so that bodies that wish to do so, such as the Human Rights Council, can benefit from remote participation in their work. That would contribute to the use of modern working methods and enable it to be more connected and inclusive.

Switzerland acknowledges all of the President's efforts over the year, which have allowed the Human Rights Council to cover its entire programme of work. The Council and its mechanisms must have enough financial and human resources to fulfil their mandate, which also means providing the necessary resources to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. That said, we regret that the briefing of the Human Rights Council by the Chair of the Peacebuilding Commission, as required by resolution 45/31, has still not taken place. It is nevertheless undeniable that human rights must be at the centre of efforts to build peace if we really wish to end cycles of conflict. We also believe firmly in the potential benefits of exchanging information between those two bodies in order to bridge the gap between the two pillars of human rights and peace and security.

The universality of all human rights was reaffirmed during the commemoration of the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, held in Geneva in December 2023. We must build on that commitment and ensure that human rights apply to everyone, everywhere. The Universal Declaration of Human

Rights affirms that the rights that it contains constitute a common standard for which all peoples and nations should strive. We should also continue to be guided by the Vienna Declaration and Programme of Action.

We deeply regret some countries' attempts to downplay their human rights obligations and even to use the principle of sovereignty to shield themselves from any external criticism of their domestic situations. The year 2024 has been marked by many serious violations and systematic violations of human rights, a significant number of which could be called war crimes and crimes against humanity. In that context, Switzerland is particularly concerned about the situation in Ukraine in the wake of the Russian military aggression, the situations in the Sudan, Afghanistan, Myanmar and China, as well as the situation in the Middle East, given the escalation of the conflict in different arenas, where too many civilians have lost their lives in Israel, in the occupied Palestinian territory or in Lebanon.

The Human Rights Council is well equipped to react to violations of human rights violations and of international humanitarian law. We believe that its overarching priority should be the quest for dialogue and cooperation with the country concerned. However, a lack of cooperation on the part of the country in question should never prevent the Council from attempting to promote and protect human rights throughout the world, or from investigating all situations that require its attention. We call on all countries concerned to cooperate with the Human Rights Council and its mechanisms and to guarantee them unhindered access.

It is in that spirit of cooperation, inclusion and dialogue that Switzerland will sit on the Human Rights Council for the next three years. We thank other Member States for the trust that they have placed in Switzerland in this election. As a member of the Council, Switzerland will commit to strengthening its capacity to respond whenever and wherever human rights violations and abuses occur. We will also contribute to the promotion and protection of human rights throughout the world through the United Nations system and in pursuing thematic initiatives. The rights of women and gender equality will receive particular attention, owing to the forthcoming thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Programme of Action. Lastly, Switzerland will continue to be committed to increasing the Human Rights Council's effectiveness.

In conclusion, Switzerland attaches particular importance to the role of civil society, including human rights defenders. Their commitment and participation are critical to the work and credibility of the United Nations. We therefore call on all Member States to cooperate with civil society organizations in Geneva, New York and throughout the world. Against that backdrop, Switzerland reaffirms that any kind of intimidation or reprisals against human rights defenders is unacceptable. All States have a responsibility to ensure that such attacks are not made on human rights defenders and that we do not see the civic space shrink.

Ms. Lortkipanidze (Georgia): At the outset, I would like to thank the President of the Human Rights Council, Ambassador Omar Zniber, for his presentation of the report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1), which clearly illustrates the importance of the Council's efforts to address numerous human rights challenges, including widespread human rights violations worldwide. Against that challenging backdrop, the Council's full implementation of its mandate is more critical than ever. Georgia, as a member of the Council, remains committed to making its humble contribution to that end.

The protection and promotion of the rights of vulnerable groups, including women and girls, children and persons with disabilities, internally displaced persons and people affected by conflict, continue to guide our efforts. I also want to underline that Georgia has spared no effort in contributing to increasing participation in the

work of the Council, including through the annual voluntary contribution to the trust fund for least developed countries and small island developing States, with the aim of supporting their unhindered engagement within the Council. Georgia fully supports the important role of civil society in the work of the Human Rights Council, given that its involvement is an indispensable element in the Council's successful implementation of its mandate and contributes to upholding the main tenets of the Charter of the United Nations.

I would like to take this opportunity to stress the importance of resolution 57/33, on cooperation with Georgia, which the Council adopted just recently at its fifty-seventh session. We are sincerely grateful to its supporters and co-sponsors. As in previous years, the resolution demands that immediate and unimpeded access to the Russian-occupied Abkhazia and Tskhinvali regions of Georgia be given to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights and other international and regional human rights mechanisms. Despite the numerous calls from the Council and the High Commissioner, the occupying Power continues to deny such access to both regions. The resolution also stresses the various decisions of the European Court of Human Rights and the International Criminal Court, which legally attest to Russia's occupation of my country's two integral regions, Abkhazia and Tskhinvali, and to the Russian Federation's responsibility for grave human rights violations there and its effective control over both regions of Georgia.

Alongside the ongoing occupation, Russia has intensified its efforts to further incorporate both regions into its social, economic, political, military and judicial domains. Ethnic discrimination against Georgians, violations of the right to life, health and property, torture and ill-treatment, restrictions on freedom of movement and education in Georgians' native language are among the numerous infringements taking place on the ground. Only last year the Russian occupation claimed the lives of two peaceful Georgian civilians, Tamaz Ginturi and Temur Karbaia. It also remains alarming that Russia has continued its practice of illegal detentions and kidnappings, which have become more protracted and more outrageous. Even the most vulnerable members of the population, such as women, the elderly and children, have been targeted by such violations. There are still Georgian citizens remaining in prolonged illegal detention in both occupied regions.

The ongoing conflicts in various parts of the world affect innocent civilians first and foremost. Numerous lives are being lost and individuals' human rights flagrantly violated. We remain deeply concerned about the grave consequences of Russia's continued war of aggression against Ukraine and its serious violations of international human rights and international humanitarian law. Georgia reaffirms its full support for the Human Rights Council's efforts in addressing the human rights implications of Russia's aggression against Ukraine.

In conclusion, let me stress that Georgia remains committed to further contributing to the Council's comprehensive implementation of its mandate for the promotion and protection of human rights at both the national and international levels.

Mr. Romero Puentes (Cuba) (*spoke in Spanish*): My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations. We welcome Ambassador Zniber and thank him for presenting the report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1).

It is an honour and a great responsibility for Cuba to be a member of the Council. Through our membership, we continue to advocate for dialogue, cooperation and mutual respect in the consideration of issues related to human rights and to oppose manipulation, selectivity and double standards. Human rights should be addressed on

the basis of the principles of universality, objectivity and non-discrimination. No country is spared challenges in the area of human rights, which means that no country should try to present itself as a model or impose its vision on the rest of the international community. The only way to move forward in this common cause is by strengthening dialogue on international cooperation.

The promotion and protection of all human rights for all people should not be used or misused on a basis of hegemonic aims. Whenever issues of human rights are addressed, it is unacceptable that we continue to see selectivity, punitive practices, double standards and political manipulation, particularly against the countries of the global South, as well as within the Human Rights Council itself and its special procedures. Attempts to point selectively to human rights situations in various developing countries are totally discriminatory. Several such countries are already victims of unilateral coercive measures, which have a significant negative impact on human rights, while a blind eye is turned to the abuses committed by highly developed countries. It is vital that those involved in special procedures observe the code of conduct adopted during the process of the establishment of the Human Rights Council and carry out their work based on objective information from trusted sources. It is regrettable that this is not always the case. Strengthening the Council on the basis of its mandate and as a subsidiary body of the General Assembly, in accordance with resolution 60/251, is a goal that we share. It must be carried out in full compliance with the so-called institution-building package.

The Universal Periodic Review remains a relevant mechanism, providing a unique forum for comprehensive reviews of the human rights situation in every country on an equal footing. Preserving that exercise is a priority. The dissolution of the former Commission on Human Rights showed the world that double standards in addressing human rights, far from contributing to the promotion and protection of human rights on the ground, only generate more confrontation and mistrust, delegitimizing the human rights machinery. The Council can and must fulfil its role better. History should not be repeated.

We live in a paradoxical world. Several countries that claim to be champions of human rights at the same time deny the existence of collective human rights. The Human Rights Council could and should do more to more strongly promote inalienable human rights such as the right to development, peace, a healthy environment and international solidarity. It will not be possible to achieve tangible advances and results in this area as long as the current unjust international order continues, whereby the hegemonic interests of a few countries prevail at the expense of the underdeveloped countries of the South. The Council could focus on promoting a more just, democratic and equitable international order, and should address the negative impact of unilateral coercive measures on the human rights of entire peoples. It is vital that the Council be allowed to fully carry out its functions. We reaffirm our opposition to efforts to establish greater links between the Human Rights Council and the Security Council or to encourage it to take on responsibilities that are not within its mandate.

The United States' blockade of Cuba is a flagrant, massive and systematic violation of the human rights of the Cuban people. Our inclusion on the spurious list of countries alleged to be sponsors of terrorism exacerbates the already challenging economic situation that our country is experiencing as a result of the embargo. The international campaign of the United States against Cuba, geared to distorting our reality, creating instability, subverting our constitutional order and justifying a policy of aggression against Cuba, will not achieve its stated purpose of subjugating us. Cuba remains strong in its ability to build an increasingly just society, following the path of socialism that our people have chosen.

Mr. Pilipenko (Belarus) (*spoke in Russian*): The Human Rights Council has been and remains an important body in the international architecture of human rights institutions, a forum for discussing every aspect of human rights. Pursuant to its mandate, the Council is obliged to address genuine human rights issues that significantly affect the quality of people's lives and to contribute to strengthening States' capacity in that area.

The Universal Periodic Review is one of the Council's most valuable and effective tools for monitoring the human rights situation in every country of the world. The statistics for the Universal Periodic Review's work show clearly that today every State needs to improve its human rights situation. Unfortunately, the Council continues to stray further and further from the principles of universality, objectivity and non-selectivity, engaging in increasingly openly politicized harassment of States. Double standards in its approaches have regrettably become the modus operandi of the Council's sessions and hallmarks of the entire institution. Thanks to that approach, many international human rights mechanisms have lost interest in States' actual achievements in realizing specific human rights and are instead basing their assessments on the extent to which national policies and strategies align with the templates imposed by the Western development model. When we leave ideology and politics aside, we see a paradox. While ostensibly fighting repression in specific countries, the Council is itself becoming a repressive body.

The double standards in its work have affected Belarus as well. Here, for example, is the Council's five-page resolution on Belarus (resolution 55/27), adopted this year at its fifty-fifth session. The situation in Belarus has a Special Rapporteur and a separate expert mechanism established within the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. The High Commissioner prepares reports on it and meetings on it are held in the Human Rights Council and the Third Committee. About $3 million is spent annually on all of that from the regular budget, that is, our contributions. And here is the size of the joint report issued this year by the foreign ministries of Belarus and Russia on human rights violations in various countries. The English version is more than 1,500 pages, and absolutely nothing has been done within the United Nations system regarding the content of this hefty volume. I hope that Belarus's position on the double standards that underlie every country mandate in the area of human rights will now be better understood. Incidentally, our joint report is available on the official website of the Belarusian Foreign Ministry.

Selective accounts of countries' situations are just one of the elements in the practice of instrumentalizing human rights for political purposes, which is undermining the credibility of the Council and its decisions. In that context, it is extremely difficult to view the integration of human rights elements into all aspects of United Nations activities as anything other than an attempt to bring ideology into international debates and multilateral institutions, including the entire United Nations system. The abuse of human rights issues is on a par with the issue of unilateral coercive measures that run counter to international law, and here we encounter another paradox. On the one hand, the work of the Human Rights Council is actively used to justify an illegal sanctions policy aimed at widespread interference in the internal affairs of independent States. On the other hand, the Council continues to ignore the negative consequences for human rights of unilateral coercive measures that are arbitrarily imposed by a group of countries, allegedly taking into account the Council's decisions. We addressed the negative impact of sanctions on the ability of sanctioned States to ensure human rights in detail, with concrete examples, right here in this Hall on 13 June at a General Assembly meeting on the subject (see A/78/PV.89). We will continue to do that during the current session and for as long as such measures are used as instruments of political and economic pressure.

Unfortunately, the report of the Human Rights Council before us (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) shows a lack of progress in addressing the problems I have mentioned and a number of other long-standing issues. We are obliged to conclude that over the past year the Council has made no effective attempts to combat politicization and double standards, imbalances in the attention paid to various categories of rights, biased assessments of human rights situations, particularly in developing countries, an excessive focus on selective country-specific subjects in its discussions or increasing confrontation among States. Nor do we support the practice of the President of the Council in arbitrarily convening dubious and unauthorized informal discussions on various issues relating to international cooperation. We believe that all substantive issues should be discussed at official meetings within the framework of the Council's agenda, in order to ensure the inclusiveness of such meetings.

It is important to point out that the problems the Council is facing do not arise from flaws in its original mandate but from the deliberate policy of certain donors to impose aggressive and destructive working methods on it. Belarus will continue take an active part in enhancing the Council's working methods, including in the context of the upcoming process on its status. Belarus has always sought to improve human rights situations. We have always been open to mutually respectful and constructive dialogue aimed at achieving genuine progress in the area. We welcome all constructive initiatives that contribute to the promotion and protection of economic, social and cultural rights, with a view to eliminating inequalities both within and among countries. But we will never accept approaches imposed on us through the Council that involve coercion and pressure, that do not take into account the specific national characteristics and aspirations of the Belarusian people and that involve interference in our internal affairs and lead to the erosion of State sovereignty. That is why the Council's report on its work in 2024 is unacceptable to us. We see no improvement in the work of the Council, and we will never accept a document that contains distorted approaches to human rights and biased assessments of the situation in Belarus.

Ms. Cedano (Dominican Republic) (*spoke in Spanish*): We appreciate the presence of Ambassador Zniber here today and thank him for presenting the Council's report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) and for his clear leadership.

The synergy between the General Assembly and the Human Rights Council is critical to ensuring an effective and coordinated response to the challenges we face. At the same time, we need to optimize our resources, avoid any duplication of effort and increase the effectiveness of our actions. These interactions are also critical to enhancing the visibility of the Council's work and its contributions in order to ensure respect for and the promotion of human rights worldwide. We emphasize our firm support for the Human Rights Council and are committed to ensuring its effectiveness and strengthening the entire human rights system, including its financing.

The Dominican Republic has taken on its role in its first year as a member of the Human Rights Council with a great sense of responsibility. We have participated enthusiastically in its interactive dialogues, supporting the full promotion and protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms. We have prioritized issues such as free education and the rights of women and girls, as well as the links between the current emerging global challenges and human rights. We have also received representatives from the working group on discrimination against women and girls, with whom we had productive exchanges aimed at strengthening our own public policies for the benefit of all women and girls in our country.

We also presented our fourth report to the Universal Periodic Review, in which we assessed the progress made and the significant challenges existing in crucial areas. We were able to highlight significant progress nationally, including improved public

policies, success in implementing our 2020–2030 national plan for achieving gender equality and progress in raising awareness about the rights of older persons. We are committed to resolving outstanding issues while ensuring that the people's dignity is central to our work. We believe firmly that presenting reports to mandate holders at the Council and the General Assembly is critical to maintaining consistency and cooperation, and to strengthening our duty to make human rights a cross-cutting issue in every area of our work. We need to improve that kind of cooperation because through it we obtain information that is vital to improving and maximizing the scope of our national initiatives.

There can be no doubt that in spite of the progress that has been made, there is a great deal to be done if we are to realize our common aspirations and goals. Strategic and collaborative planning, working together and fostering dialogue through transparent continued exchanges between the Human Rights Council, the General Assembly and other agencies within the United Nations system and all relevant stakeholders are all crucial elements in bringing about a sustained, deep-seated impact on the lives and future of people whom we are called on to serve.

We cannot allow the times we live in to undermine our political will. On the contrary, we must use it as an impetus to achieve the commitments that we have made and enshrined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and that are part of our shared responsibility to build a fully sustainable future for all without any distinction.

Mr. Mahmoud (Egypt) (*spoke in Arabic*): Egypt has participated actively in the institutional building of the Human Rights Council, and we will continue to focus attention on the governing rules of the Council's work. The Council's constitutive document stipulates that it will continue to assume its responsibility as a principal subsidiary body of the General Assembly, in line with the Assembly's resolution 60/251, which established it. The Council derives special importance from its role in strengthening and promoting human rights, one of the three founding pillars of the United Nations together with development and peace and security, all on an equal footing.

We are discussing the Council's annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) against a very bleak backdrop, primarily that of the armed conflicts where we are seeing human rights principles eroded in the face of the killing machines that are murdering civilians. A particular example of that is the situation in Gaza, where Israel's war has now lasted for over a year and has killed more than 42,000 civilian martyrs, including thousands of children, women and elderly people. In addition to the destruction of civilian infrastructure and the targeting of shelters, humanitarian aid convoys and aid workers, Palestinians are being denied their means of livelihood, with starvation used as a method of warfare along with total deprivation of healthcare and education, exposing a whole generation of Palestinian children to health risks. That has been accompanied by attacks on journalists and media outlets and the denial of Internet services.

Israel's brutal attacks in Gaza and their extension to the West Bank are grave violations of international humanitarian law and international human rights law, there for the whole world to see. Without accountability, not only has Israel been able to violate the Palestinian people's right to self-determination through its ongoing occupation, but as an occupying Power has been violating Palestinian human rights — the right to life, food, drinking water, education and healthcare — along with civic and political rights such as freedom of expression and assembly, freedom from political arrest or torture in Israeli jails, and so on. We insist on maintaining agenda item 7 of the Human Rights Council as a separate item on the situation of human rights in the occupied Palestinian territory and the other occupied territories, and we support the mandates established under that agenda item. We support the reports of

the Special Rapporteurs documenting Israel's violations of its obligations in the occupied Palestinian territory under international human rights law and international humanitarian law. In that regard, we want to emphasize that silence in the face of Israel's violations undermines the credibility of the international community in discussions of the pivotal role of the protection and promotion of human rights alongside the achievement of international peace and security and sustainable development for all without discrimination. The Council was established to restore a consensus around this pivotal issue that the Human Rights Commission lacked, and we regret the growing disagreements and politicization within the Human Rights Council that have weakened its ability to fully assume its responsibilities.

Since Egypt will soon discuss its fourth national report under the Universal Periodic Review, we want to emphasize the role of that mechanism in strengthening and fostering dialogue and cooperation among countries in the area of human rights, which reflects a constructive approach to protecting and promoting human rights. That should take into account the independent sovereignty of countries that differ socially, culturally and in terms of levels of development and the resources that are available to them to fulfil all their international legal obligations in the area of human rights. Here we would like to remind everyone that the principles on which the Human Rights Council was established — impartiality, objectivity, non-selectivity, constructive dialogue and cooperation — are the same ones that we should all uphold. In that regard, Egypt rejects all attempts to impose controversial concepts or value systems on countries without taking their specific cultural, societal and historical contexts into account.

While the increasing spread of new technologies and their use and development, including artificial intelligence, as well as digital social media platforms, provide many opportunities to promote a culture of respect for human rights, they also create many risks and challenges such as the promotion of hate speech, incitements to violence and negative stereotypes, as well as enabling the existence of multiple platforms that enable rhetoric promoting racial discrimination, xenophobia and other forms of intolerance. That has the potential to undermine the efforts being made to eliminate such discrimination and racism in all their forms, as well as undermining human values and violating the human rights of the groups that are targeted. They include immigrants of African descent and Muslim communities in the diaspora, for example, many of whom are facing discrimination on a basis of religion in a manner that violates States' responsibilities to protect and respect the human rights of all without distinction or discrimination. Such platforms and technologies are also a threat to women's rights, because they provide tools that can be misused to promote discrimination against women and the progress that has been made on ensuring their human rights. Another very real threat is extremely urgent in terms of protecting human rights and human security in the digital age, and it is vital that we take note of its risks and act to combat them. During the Council's fifty-sixth session we discussed the security of children in the digital environment and adopted resolution 56/6 on the topic by consensus.

I would also like to recall here that we need concerted efforts to govern such technological frameworks in a manner that prevents them from being misused so as to violate human rights. In that regard, I would like to point to article 15 of the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights — which stipulates that everyone has a right to enjoy the benefits of scientific progress and its applications, and that States parties play a role in supporting, promoting and disseminating science and culture — as well as article 27 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, on the right to share in scientific advancement and its benefits. We should therefore work to reinvigorate the international cooperative frameworks in the areas of technology and the transfer of technology to developing countries, ensuring

that citizens of those countries can participate in that right and in the advancement of science and its tools with a view to responding to the needs of all peoples everywhere.

We should also discuss the pivotal importance of adopting the right to development on an equal footing with all other human rights, including the full integration of human rights elements into the Sustainable Development Goals. The time has come to adopt a legally binding international document on the right to development, which can be done when the Human Rights Council's refers a text of the draft convention on the subject to the General Assembly.

Egypt will continue to engage constructively and positively with the Human Rights Council, including through its membership of the Council. In line with that, we hope that members will support our re-election to the Council for the 2026–2028 term in the elections to be held in New York in October 2025.

Mr. Abd Karim (Malaysia): Malaysia would like to express its appreciation to Ambassador Omar Zniber, President of the Human Rights Council, for presenting the Council's annual report (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). We also want to commend the work of the Council's 2024 Bureau under his leadership.

The Human Rights Council holds significant importance for Malaysia, as it serves as a platform for promoting and protecting human rights both domestically and globally. Through our participation in the Council, Malaysia has been able to engage in constructive dialogue, share best practices and learn from the experiences of other Member States. That collaboration is vital to advancing our human rights agenda and fostering a culture of respect and inclusivity within our society. As Malaysia's three-year term as a member of the Council comes to a close, we would like to reflect on our commitment to constructive cooperation and mutual respect in the collective pursuit of promoting and protecting human rights.

Malaysia is pleased to note that consensus was achieved within the Council on some issues this year, including on the issue of education as a tool to prevent racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia and related forms of intolerance and on marking the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, as well as the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan. We are also honoured that the Council's resolution on "Safety of the child in the digital environment" (resolution 56/6), which was sponsored by a core group that included Malaysia, was adopted by consensus. We hope it will serve as a catalyst for building further consensus within the Council.

Despite the Council's commendable efforts and achievements in the past year, we are increasingly concerned about the growing polarization and divisions within the Council, which limit our collective ability to effectively address urgent human rights issues. We should remember that the Human Rights Council was created in order to address the rampant politicization and polarization of its predecessor and to restore the credibility of the body designed to promote and protect human rights. We must not repeat the problems of the former Commission on Human Rights, which resulted from a loss of confidence and commitment on the part of States regarding the importance of its institutional role. In line with the universality of human rights, it is imperative to ensure that all human rights violations are addressed with the same degree of urgency and vigour wherever they occur. We should not turn a blind eye to long-standing human rights violations. Malaysia regrets that such long-standing violations, particularly the systemic oppression of Palestinians and the Rohingya, have been allowed to persist. It is crucial that the Human Rights Council take decisive action to promptly put an end to such atrocities, in accordance with its mandate.

We also regret that key concepts within the human rights framework, such as the right to development and the fight against racism, racial discrimination,

xenophobia and related intolerance as outlined in the Durban Declaration and Programme of Action, as well as the negative impacts of unilateral coercive measures on human rights, continue to encounter resistance within the Human Rights Council. Conversely, there are persistent attempts based on political convenience to reinterpret principles of international law and existing agreed terminologies that clearly disregard national and regional contexts. Such actions threaten the concept of the universality, indivisibility, interdependence and interrelatedness of human rights and undermine the effective functioning of the Council.

With the Council's workload continuing to grow, as we have seen during its past three sessions, Malaysia believes it is urgent that we address the Council's working methods with a view to safeguarding its efficiency and effectiveness. Failure to do so may jeopardize the Council's ability to fulfil its critical mandate. An approach that could be considered is that of avoiding overlapping initiatives that can lead to inefficiencies while straining the Council's limited resources.

Malaysia is also concerned about the postponement of certain Human Rights Council-mandated activities scheduled for implementation in 2024 owing to the liquidity crisis at the United Nations. Those delays have impacted numerous technical-assistance and capacity-building activities mandated by various Council resolutions, which are particularly crucial for developing countries. While we appreciate the efforts to navigate the challenges posed by the liquidity crisis, we regret that the postponed activities are related to economic, social and cultural rights, as well as the right to development, and to technical cooperation for the establishment and maintenance of an online repository for the implementation of Universal Periodic Review recommendations, while at the same time many country-specific issues have remained unaffected. In that regard, a strategic approach, based on inclusive consultation with Member States, should be implemented to address the Organization's liquidity crisis and its broader impact on human rights initiatives.

There is also a pressing need to strengthen the synergies between the Human Rights Council and processes in New York. There appears to be a disconnect between the outcomes achieved within the Council and their incorporation into broader New York processes. In order to see more effective and comprehensive results, we should adopt a holistic approach that harmonizes the three pillars of the United Nations.

Malaysia's engagement with the Council will continue to reflect a belief in the importance of inclusivity, mutual respect and transparency, as we strive to uphold the dignity and rights of all individuals. As we move forward, Malaysia calls on all States to contribute actively to strengthening the Council's effectiveness, so that its mandate is upheld decisively, remains relevant and is responsive to current needs and challenges.

Mr. Al Nahhas (Syrian Arab Republic) (*spoke in Arabic*): My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends for the Defence of the Charter of the United Nations, and I would like to add the following remarks in my national capacity.

First, our delegation would like to express its appreciation to Ambassador Omar Zniber, the President of the Human Rights Council. We thank him for his briefing and for presenting the report of the Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1).

The Syrian Arab Republic attaches the utmost importance to the promotion and protection of human rights, with no discrimination based on race, sex, religion or nationality. We believe that cooperation and dialogue are the most important elements for promoting and protecting those rights, in accordance with the principles of impartiality, objectivity and non-politicization, while giving due respect to the

principles of sovereignty and equality and without interfering in the internal affairs of States, as stipulated in the Charter of the United Nations.

However, what we have witnessed over the past few years and what we are witnessing today in occupied Palestine, Lebanon and my own country, Syria, unambiguously exposes the falsity of Western countries' claims that they care about and defend human rights. Those countries have remained silent and have not lifted a finger to defend the assault on the human rights of Arab peoples by Israel's killing, destruction and displacement machine. My delegation has always seen this as a demonstration of a double standard and selectivity with regard to human rights, and we urge that this noble issue not be politicized. However, various well-known Western countries are taking advantage of this Organization and some of its subsidiary bodies, including the Human Rights Council, to launch systematic smear campaigns and to make false and baseless allegations in order to exert political pressure that serves only their own narrow and selfish interests.

My country rejects such practices, and we affirm the important role of the Human Rights Council in upholding and promoting human rights and preventing their weaponization or use as a politicized tool to target some countries and not others, as well as in fostering dialogue among countries. Here I would like to note that the Universal Periodic Review is the most appropriate and non-discriminatory mechanism for ensuring constructive discussions on the state of human rights throughout the world.

My country renews its categorical rejection of the continued and growing proliferation of country-specific resolutions, mechanisms and politicized procedures that purport to conduct impartial evaluations and investigations of the state of human rights in some countries without the consent of the country concerned. That is not to mention the fact that those reports lack credibility, as they are based on sources whose reliability cannot be verified or others that are biased or hostile to the country in question, reducing the reports to smear campaigns that are subsequently used for malicious purposes. The imposition of unilateral coercive measures clearly exposes the political hypocrisy displayed by some countries. While they pay lip service to defending human rights, they resort to inhumane and illegal measures that violate every human right, especially the right to life, health and development. Such measures constitute collective punishment of a people and a crime against humankind and billions of people all over the world.

In conclusion, my country affirms its support for the Human Rights Council's agenda item 7, on the human rights situation in Palestine and other occupied Arab territories, and demands accountability for the real violators of human rights, including the right to life, particularly regarding Israel's criminal occupation and the countries that supply it with weapons and materiel as well as unlimited political support.

Ms. Dautllari (Albania): Albania expresses its gratitude to President Omar Zniber for presenting the Human Rights Council's annual report to the General Assembly (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1). We appreciate his dedication and leadership in guiding the Council's work during a time of escalating human rights crises worldwide.

Today, as we are facing sustained pushback and resistance to the entire human rights agenda, it is our responsibility to work together to strengthen the Council's ability to address both traditional and emerging threats, while aiming for the effective enjoyment of human rights. Albania remains a strong supporter of the Human Rights Council and its work to promote and protect human rights. We strongly believe that human rights are universal, indivisible, interdependent, interrelated and inherent to

every person, regardless of nationality, gender, ethnicity, race, religion, language or other status.

Respect for human rights and the fundamental freedoms for all individuals and groups is essential to ensuring lasting peace, security and sustainable development. Through its various mechanisms, such as special procedures, an investigative mechanism and the Universal Periodic Review, the Council plays a crucial role in promoting and defending human rights on a global scale. We should advocate for greater use of human rights information in our common efforts to develop effective early-warning mechanisms and early-response capabilities. Human rights are and should be used as a valuable set of tools for the work of conflict prevention, peacebuilding and sustaining peace.

Albania, alongside countries worldwide, supported the renewal of the mandate of the Special Rapporteur for Human Rights in Russia, as well as the renewal of the mandate of the Independent International Commission of Inquiry on Ukraine stemming from the ongoing Russian aggression.

Albania remains deeply concerned about restrictions on civil society around the globe and stresses the importance of civil society's participation in democratic systems. We call on all nations to protect civil society and denounce any threats or reprisals against those who cooperate with United Nations human rights mechanisms. The ability for individuals and groups to engage with the Council without fear of reprisal is crucial to the effectiveness of those mechanisms.

As a member of the Human Rights Council, Albania has prioritized and will continue to prioritize various areas, the first of which is strengthening accountability. We will work to strengthen the role of treaty bodies, special procedures and the Universal Periodic Review, which together form the basic pillars of the United Nations system for ensuring accountability for all violations of human rights. The second is the promotion of women's rights and gender equality. We firmly believe that putting women and girls at the centre of peace and security is a good investment in long-lasting and more sustainable peace. The third is the promotion of civic space and the protection of human rights defenders, whose active and meaningful participation in the work of the Human Rights Council should be preserved and promoted. To that end, we should prioritize combating all forms of intimidation and reprisals against civil society actors, especially those who engage with the United Nations. The fourth and last is the protection and promotion of children's rights. Albania will work to expand concrete and decisive action to improve the situation of children worldwide, driven by a human rights-based approach that puts children at its centre and filters analysis through the lens of the Convention on the Rights of the Child.

In conclusion, we need to reflect on ways to improve the human rights system and make it stronger. While we can discuss the best ways to achieve that, one thing is certain. We must work together to address the challenges to human rights that the human rights system is facing. Albania stands ready to actively engage for a strengthened and effective human rights system.

Mrs. Kasymaliyeva (Kyrgyzstan): We thank the President of the Human Rights Council for presenting a comprehensive and informative account of the Council's work (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1).

The Human Rights Council is the central human rights body of the United Nations, and as such plays a crucial role in further advancing and protecting human rights. As a current member of the Council, Kyrgyzstan remains fully committed to the Council's core mandate and actively contributes to its implementation. I would

like to take this opportunity to flag some of the key aspects of our work in the Council during its most recent session and in the near future.

First, we welcomed the unanimous adoption of resolution 56/15, entitled "Informing the Human Rights Council on the human rights adviser programme". It was presented by Kyrgyzstan on behalf of a core group of countries — Latvia, Paraguay, Sierra Leone, Sweden, the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland and my own country, Kyrgyzstan — and co-sponsored by 49 Member States. The resolution is aimed at increasing awareness of the programme among Member States and shining a light on its key achievements, the challenges it faces and the positive input it can potentially contribute for all of us. The Human Rights Adviser Programme is a pivotal initiative within the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights that supports the robust enhancement of national capacities in addressing human rights challenges across the globe. We believe that a deeper understanding in the Council of the Programme will help to strengthen its focus on supporting countries that are underrepresented in Geneva, ensuring that their human rights challenges are addressed and that they receive the advisory assistance they need.

Secondly, as this year marks the forty-fifth anniversary of the adoption of the Convention on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women and the twenty-fifth anniversary of the adoption of its optional protocol, while next year we celebrate the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Programme of Action, we would like to reiterate the importance of those legal documents and recommit to gender equality and the empowerment of all women and girls. As a current member of the Human Rights Council, Kyrgyzstan continues to work tirelessly with other Council members to contribute actively to the achievement of those goals. Ambassador Omar Sultanov presented a joint statement in Geneva in June on the economic empowerment of women and girls, co-sponsored by 85 countries. In July, the Kyrgyz Mission in Geneva, together with other Central Asian States and the European Union Mission, organized a side event entitled "Addressing gender-based violence, a pathway to economic growth, inclusion and sustainable development". Committed to making further progress on women's economic empowerment, Kyrgyzstan intends to introduce a draft resolution on the economic empowerment of women and girls in Geneva next year. We hope for constructive engagement and support from all delegations in that process.

Last but not least, let me touch on the ongoing liquidity crisis at the United Nations Office in Geneva. We are concerned about the message that the Office may end its online broadcast of all Council meetings and thereby the formation of a video archive. We believe that our broadcasts and video archives serve as a tool for transparency in the Council's work and a key element of institutional memory. That is especially important for small and developing States with a small diplomatic staff, as is the case with my country. On 24 June, in an attempt to prevent this from happening, 104 Member States, including Kyrgyzstan, sent a joint letter to the Director-General of the United Nations Office in Geneva. Furthermore, at its meeting on 10 July, the Council adopted by consensus decision 56/115, which strengthened the documentation of the Human Rights Council webcast. It was decided that all formal public meetings of the Council both during and between sessions, as well as meetings of its subsidiary bodies and mechanisms, including the working group on the Universal Periodic Review, should continue to be webcast live in all official languages of the United Nations, and that those proceedings subsequently be stored. The Secretary-General was requested to provide all the necessary resources. We hope for positive consideration of that request and underscore the importance of maintaining the full functioning of the Council.

Mrs. Bouchikhi (Morocco): It is a national honour and a personal privilege for me to address the General Assembly today on the presentation of the annual report of the Human Rights Council (A/79/53 and A/79/53/Add.1) under the capable leadership of His Excellency Mr. Omar Zniber, the Moroccan President of the Human Rights Council.

At the outset, I would like to express my warm congratulations to the President of the Human Rights Council, his team and the Secretariat on their work and commendable efforts in leading the Council with determined professionalism and total dedication to overcoming polarization and instrumentalization in an effort to uphold respect for and the promotion of human rights and fundamental freedoms. In that regard, we would like to applaud the presidency for undertaking several timely initiatives this year, particularly on the impact of climate change, food security and health security, as well as the effects and challenges of artificial intelligence in the enjoyment of human rights.

We are sincerely grateful to the President of the Council for his personal efforts to bridge the gap between Geneva and New York through his constant visits to Headquarters in New York in order to meet and exchange views with principals and high officials of the United Nations on matters pertaining to his mandates and their respective mandates. Morocco also commends the President for maintaining the past practice of regularly sharing timely and succinct summaries about recent developments in the Human Rights Council with Member States in New York, through the President of the General Assembly. Indeed, despite the complexity of the international political context and the increase in financial constraints that have been a major threat to the Council's ability to fulfil its important mandates, the President has been able to step up efforts to rationalize the work of the Council and improve its efficiency and harmonization.

Morocco is resolutely committed to building a modern democratic State based on democracy and the rule of law. In that regard, Morocco solemnly affirms its deep commitment to respecting, promoting and upholding human rights, as well as taking continued action aimed at their consolidation, both nationally and internationally. Morocco's election to the Presidency of the Human Rights Council reflects the international recognition of the progress and development made by the Kingdom in the field of human rights. Under the far-sighted leadership of His Majesty King Mohammed VI, Morocco has undertaken profound normative and institutional reforms aimed at reinforcing the universal values of human rights and promoting equality between men and women, pluralism, peaceful coexistence and dialogue. That has been further reinforced by the Morocco's adoption of a national action plan for democracy and human rights, which is devoted to promoting a general culture of human rights.

Morocco believes firmly that strengthening the treaty body system is the cornerstone for the international protection of human rights. A follow-up process is therefore the most appropriate way to achieve the goal of strengthening and enhancing the effective functioning of the human rights treaty body system, based on the implementation of the report of the 2020 human rights treaty body review process that Morocco had the honour to co-facilitate with Switzerland (A/75/601). In that regard, between 2022 and 2024 the Kingdom interacted with four treaty bodies, the Committee of the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women in June 2022, the Committee on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of their Families in March 2023, the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination in September 2023 and very recently with the Committee on Enforced Disappearances. In the same vein, 12 United Nations mandate holders have visited Morocco since 2011. For the period from 2024 to 2025, Morocco has invited

six mandate holders to visit the Kingdom. Four of them have already given their agreements, and two are in progress. The Kingdom is therefore the country that has received the greatest number of visits from the human rights special procedures in our region.

Additionally, since 2014 Morocco has continued its considerable efforts as an active member and leading State of the core group of the Convention against Torture Initiative, to raise awareness of torture and to promote the universal ratification and better implementation of the United Nations Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment. In that regard, Morocco is pleased that since its launch, the Torture Initiative has supported new States parties in joining the Convention. Furthermore, Morocco recently joined Switzerland and Argentina at the launch of the Secretary-General's guidance note on transitional justice as a strategic tool for people, prevention and peace. My delegation continues to believe firmly that justice and peace remain two complementary United Nations principles and foundations.

Morocco is pleased to be continuing to present, with Argentina and France, its biennial resolution on enforced disappearances, and remains resolutely convinced of the importance of ensuring universal ratification of the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance. This year Morocco is also presenting to the Third Committee its traditional biennial draft resolution on the role of the Ombudsman and mediator institutions in the promotion and protection of human rights, good governance and the rule of law, which in this session emphasizes the importance of Sustainable Development Goal 16, on access to justice. Morocco is also among the leading core group that presented resolution 45/8, which for the first time declared a clean, healthy and sustainable environment a human right. Similarly, Morocco is an active member of the core group that presented the General Assembly's landmark resolution 76/300, which recognized the same right.

Given the royal attachment to the promotion of women's issues and the family in general, in September 2023 King Mohammed instructed his Government to launch a reform of the Moroccan family code, aimed at keeping pace with the changes taking place in Moroccan society, where tradition and modernity go hand in hand, as well as at strengthening women's rightful place within Moroccan society. The process has been conducted in a well-defined and inclusive framework, including consultation with all relevant stakeholders. Morocco has also maintained its momentum in consolidating the rights of migrants and refugees by regularizing the legal situation and allowing them to exercise their rights through the implementation of our national immigration and asylum strategy. Accordingly, Morocco welcomes the convening of the Human Rights Council intersessional panel discussion on ways to prevent and address human rights violations and abuse of migrants in transit and to ensure access to justice for victims and their family members. Bearing in mind the cross-cutting nature of human rights, Morocco looks forward to the upcoming World Social Summit, which Morocco and Belgium have the honour to co-facilitate, and its outcomes. Morocco reiterates its belief that this important Summit constitutes a vital opportunity to address challenges faced by developing countries in terms of social development.

Morocco's attachment to the values of mutual coexistence and the rejection of hatred and intolerance are firm and ongoing. My country was the proud initiator of General Assembly resolutions 73/328, 75/309 and 77/318, on hate speech, and that which we proclaim on 18 June each year in support of the International Day for Countering Hate Speech. In that regard, Morocco welcomes the plans to convene a conference in Geneva in 2025 against hate speech. We would like to take this opportunity to renew our willingness and full commitment to working together with

the Human Rights Council, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights and all relevant mandate holders and stakeholders to ensure the full success of that event.

Morocco is pleased to be a strong partner of the Alliance of Civilizations and is deeply committed to reinforcing our long-standing relationship to preserve its important mandate as a platform for dialogue, the promotion of peace and the advancement of diplomacy and diversity worldwide, as a follow-up to the ninth Global Forum of the Alliance of Civilizations, held in Fez, Morocco, in November 2022. As a founding member of the Human Rights Council, Morocco has played a leading role in the design of the Council's working mechanism. Morocco has worked diligently and continues to invest nationally, regionally and internationally in the promotion of human rights and the strengthening of the Human Rights Council as an irreversible commitment.

In conclusion, Morocco reaffirms its irreversible and strategic commitment to human rights, demonstrating its continued desire to promote the universal values of dignity, justice and the rule of law. The Kingdom will hold its continuing and constructive interaction with the United Nations human rights system, and in particular the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, the Universal Periodic Review and the various conventions of the human rights treaty body system.

The Acting President: We have heard the last speaker in the debate for this meeting. We will hear the remaining speakers on Tuesday, 5 November, at 10 a.m. in this Hall, after we have exhausted the list of speakers for the already scheduled items.

The General Assembly has thus concluded this stage of its consideration of agenda item 66.

The meeting rose at 1 p.m.